ONE-OFF SHIURIM

How Do We Serve God? The Four Kinds of Misvot

Derech Hashem 4:1:1-5

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 1, paragraphs 1-5 (the whole chapter) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 13 January 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The final part of Derech Hashem

This short recording opens Part 4, the fourth and final part of the book. Part 1 was about God; Part 2 about His relationship with humanity; Part 3 about how God reveals Himself, through dreams, prophecy and the rest. Part 4 is "the most practical, in the sense that it's the most pertinent to us". The Ramhal will take us through our daily and yearly calendar and explain what we do and why, at a deeper level than we are used to. It is about the service of our Creator.

"I hope now you're starting to get used to the style of the Ramhal." He always begins by dividing a subject into categories and sub-categories, exactly as the Rambam does.

Paragraphs 1-2: study and action

The service of God divides into two parts: **study** and **action** (observance). Action is further divided into four categories:

1. **Constant** (*tamidi*)
2. **Daily** (*yomi*)
3. **Periodic** (*zemani*)
4. **Circumstantial** (*mikri*)

The Rabbi tested the group. What is constant? Belief in God. Daily? Prayer. Periodic? Shabbat and the festivals. Circumstantial? Birkat HaGomel, or a mezuzah, which applies only if you have a home. A participant suggested that mezuzah is constant; no, if you have no home there is no obligation. Another suggested sisit; it applies only by day and only to a four-cornered garment, so it is both periodic and circumstantial.

Paragraph 3: the six constant misvot

A constant misvah applies at all times, in all places, to everyone, man or woman. There are six:

- Belief in God

- Not believing in other gods
- The unity of God
- Love of God
- Fear of God
- Not straying after our heart and our eyes

The last, the Rabbi said, covers straying both in belief and in desire. Some of the six overlap. "Those are the only six constant misvot which we have."

Daily, periodic and circumstantial

Daily misvot are what one is obliged to do every day. When the Temple stood, the daily korbanot; today, Tefillah and Kriat Shema.

Periodic misvot apply only at certain times: Shabbat, Yom Tov, shaking the lulav, blowing the shofar.

Circumstantial misvot apply only when something happens. A person can live his whole life as a fully observant Jew and never take hallah: only if you bake bread are you obliged. The Rabbi asked participants whether they had ever taken hallah; they had not, and did not need to. Maaser of animals applies only if you own animals. Most of us will never perform Pidyon HaBen. Shehitah is required only if you wish to eat meat; there is no obligation to slaughter.

A participant asked about honouring parents. That too is circumstantial, the Rabbi said, since it depends on having parents. He gave the example of a person whose father died before he was born and whose mother died in childbirth: rare, but it shows the category.

They then tried a few more. Halisah: circumstantial, depending on a woman whose husband died without children. Shiluah HaKen: circumstantial, only if you come across a nest. Not coveting: a participant pointed out that this applies only if your neighbour has something; another, that even "do not kill" applies only when there is someone to kill. Within each category there are both positive and negative commandments: "turn from bad and do good".

Paragraph 4: the purpose of it all

The Ramhal recalls what he explained in Part 1. The general purpose of everything is to turn to God and seek His closeness through the misvot, which bring us near to Him. We must remove from ourselves all the bad which ties us to darkness and materiality, and draw ourselves close to Him, until we cleave to Him and become complete, in His likeness. "That's all God wants. That's the whole purpose of creation."

Paragraph 5: the plan ahead

Now the Ramhal will go into detail: how each kind of service brings us to perfection, starting with the misvot that apply at all times and in all places. The plan for the rest of the book: next chapter, the study of Torah; then the constant misvot; then the daily misvot; then the periodic; and then the circumstantial, which brings us to the end of the book.

Summary

- Part 4 explains the misvot we actually do, at a deeper level.
- Service of God divides into study and action.
- Action divides into constant, daily, periodic and circumstantial misvot.
- There are only six constant misvot, all of them matters of belief, love, fear and guarding the heart and eyes.
- The purpose of all the misvot is to draw close to God and cleave to Him.

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